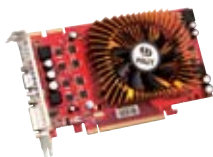


Entry-level Graphics Cards				
Brand Model Name	Palit HD3850 Super	PowerColor HD 3850	Sapphire HD3850	GeCube 3650
				
GPU Name	HD 3850	HD 3850	HD 3850	HD 3650
Price (Rs)	5950	6900	6900	4650
Total Score (Out of 100)	58.95	69.66	65.36	20.91
Features (Out of 30)	17.69	20.90	19.61	6.27
Performance (Out of 70)	41.27	48.76	45.75	14.64
Features				
Core Speed (MHz)	670	720	668	725
Memory Speed (MHz)	1660	1800	1656	800
No Of Stream Processors	320	320	320	120
VRAM Type	GDDR3	GDDR3	GDDR3	DDR2
Amount of VRAM (In Megabytes)	512	512	512	1024
Memory Bus Width (In Bits)	256	256	256	128
GPU Fabrication Process	55nm	55nm	55nm	55nm
No of DVI Ports	2	1	2	2
Dual Monitor Support (Y/N)	Y	Y	Y	Y
HDMI (Y/N)	Y	Y	Y (adapter)	N
Accessory / Connector Bundle	S-Video to component adapter, 4 pin power adapter, DVI to D-Sub adapter	S-Video to component adapter, 4 pin power adapter, DVI to D-Sub adapter	S-Video to component adapter, 4 pin power adapter, DVI to D-Sub adapter	S-Video to component adapter, 4 pin power adapter, DVI to D-Sub adapter
Game Bundle	N	N	N	N
Performance				
Crysis				
1280 x 1024 (Max Detail, 4x AA)	16.92	18.83	17.74	6.01
1024 x 768 (Max Detail, No AA)	24.68	27.1	24.68	8.95
Unreal Tournament 3 (Deimos)				
1280 x 1024 (8 xAF, 4x AA, Max Detail)	80	82	80	32
1024 x 768 (4x AF, No AA, Max Detail)	82	86	88	46
S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Shadow of Chernobyl				
1280 x 1024 (4xAF, 4x AA, Max Detail)	80	85.62	78.9	26.69
1024 x 768 (4x AF, No AA, Max Detail)	107.6	113.01	105.5	37.84
Company of Heroes: Opposing Fronts				
1280 x 1024 (4x AF, No AA, Max Detail)	82.5	90.4	81	25.9
World In Conflict				
1280 x 1024 (4x AF, 4x AA, Max Detail)	19	34	32	8
1024 x 768 (4x AF, No AA, Medium Detail)	53	66	70	36
F.E.A.R (Avg FPS)				
1280 x 1024 (4x AA, 4x AF, Max Detail)	75	83	77	20
3D Mark Vantage (GPU Score)	3633	3956	3609	829

light away from the 8800 GTX and its ilk. Although at first glance its core specifications seem to put it into a league of performance cards the reality wasn't so for ATI – sadly the HD 3870 failed, and so did the HD 3850 from its allotted task to steak the GeForce 8800 GT's thunder. With

a GDDR3 memory interface and a whopping 320 SPs the Radeon HD 3850 has seen a huge fall from grace...and price. Cards based on this GPU are actually terrific bang for buck. The only demerit is these cards run hotter than the GeForce 9600 GTs, of course they're older chipsets as well.

Features

We got four Radeon HD 3850 based cards – one each from ASUS, Palit, Sapphire and PowerColor. ASUS and Sapphire provide DVI to HDMI adapters. The other two i.e. Palit and PowerColor actually provide an HDMI port on the rear panel of their cards. PowerColor

provides a D-Sub port too, at the expense of one DVI port. All vendors supply all the necessary cables and connectors though nobody bothers with any games.

Performance

ASUS uses DDR2 RAM on their HD 3850 and give you an extra 512 MB. All other vendors use faster GDDR3 memory and make do with 512 MB. PowerColor overclocked their card to a 720 MHz core; all other vendors kept their cards at the default 670 MHz. As expected the ASUS HD 3850 was noticeably slower than the other cards because of its slower memory. This shows that just having more RAM isn't a guarantee of performance – the memory should be clocked fast

too. This also proves that today's games are bandwidth hogs. It's also possible that the extra frame buffer isn't being used by those 320 SPs. Besides Crysis and World In Conflict this card can handle all the games we tested it's performance under. We noticed these cards are noticeably slower than the 9600 GT and 9600 GSO GPUs.

Radeon HD 3650

Not so golden oldie

The HD 3650 was intended as a mid-range offering after ATI had mediocre success with the Radeon HD 2600 XT. As a DX 10 part the HD 3650 has 120 SPs, which may seem a lot, but as we've seen before the num-

Entertainment system killer...the HTPC?

By now you must be sick to death about us spewing expletives about just how good an HTPC really is and how everyone interested in a cinematic experience at home should get one. So why is an HTPC special? If you assemble one which components in your home theatre system become obsolete? Can an HTPC better a home theatre system? The fact is that an HTPC is meant to deliver great bang for buck for those looking to up to Rs 1,00,000 on a media source. By source we mean the DVD/Blu-Ray player. Obviously you'll still need killer surround sound and a large screen LCD or Plasma display capable of 1080p natively. Anything less these days is a waste of popcorn; not to mention time.

Suppose you have a set of 5.1 speakers and a 55-inch plasma screen. Or maybe you went overboard and bought a 1080p projector and a projection screen with a 120-inch display area. Now you need a player. Here's where the HTPC seriously kicks any sources bottom – you simply cannot match an HTPC for performance and versatility. If you simply want to watch Blu-Ray content, a Blu-Ray player costing around Rs 20,000 will do the trick. But what about when you want to watch an HD movie that is not encoded by any format recognised by your player? Or you have an HD file that's encoded at a non-standard HD resolution like say 1440 x 720 pixels. Your player can only play 720p/720i (1280 x 720 pixels) or 1080p / 1080i (1920 x 1080 pixels). So you're stuck. What if you download a really good movie that's in some non-standard format or resolution? You can do nothing because your player will not play it.

A computer, with its infinite software decoding capabilities can help you out of this situation. Windows Media Player, VLC, Real Player and PowerDVD working in conjunction with each other can play almost any format and any resolution. A simple dual core processor, 1 GB of RAM and anything later than a GeForce 8 series card or Radeon HD 2xxx series card will easily do the trick. HTPC cabinets along with media centre remote units are available for as low as Rs 6,000. Install a Blu-Ray drive and you can play Blu-Ray content of your optical drive as well, else you can always rip movies and store them. Such an HTPC can also double as a download box – though you will need a larger hard drive, maybe two. An HTPC with a decent graphics solution can also be used to game occasionally. HDMI is a must for large screen entertainment as most displays have this standard. We suggest you give an HTPC a try, before throwing cash away on other video sources.

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